

Self-Extinguishing Pocket Ashtray

Add water, drop the butt, done — clean cigarette disposal businesses pay for in bulk.

What It Is

A portable, eco-friendly ashtray shaped like a small paper cup. Add a splash of water, drop the cigarette in, and it self-extinguishes — no loose ash, less odor, no messy cleanup. It's sold both as a B2B bulk product to hospitality venues and as a branded consumer item for smokers on the go.

How It Makes Money

Two channels: (1) bulk sales to cafes, restaurants, terraces, hotels, hookah lounges, and outdoor events that hate dealing with cigarette mess and want a cleaner patio experience; (2) DTC packs to individual smokers and travelers online. Recurring revenue comes from venues reordering the disposable cups, plus custom-branded printing for businesses that want their logo on the cup.

Startup Costs

- Inventory from Alibaba: portable paper/pulp pocket ashtrays, ~\$0.08–\$0.25/unit landed; 5,000 units = \$400–\$1,000
- Custom branding/printing setup (optional, for B2B): \$100–\$300 plate/setup
- Retail packaging for DTC multi-packs: \$80–\$150
- Shopify + domain: ~\$30/month
- Samples to leave with venues: \$50–\$100
- Business cards / simple flyer: \$40
- **Total to start: \$400–\$1,200**

Alibaba sourcing: search "portable pocket ashtray" or "disposable paper ashtray." Order a sample pack to confirm the water-extinguish design holds liquid and folds flat for cheap shipping.

The Numbers

- Cost per unit landed: **~\$0.15**
- DTC sell price: **\$1.50–\$3 each**, or 10-packs at \$15–\$20
- B2B bulk sell price: **\$0.40–\$0.70 each** to venues (they buy 500–2,000 at a time)
- Profit per unit: DTC ~\$1.30; B2B ~\$0.30
- Realistic monthly: land 15 venues reordering 1,000/month at \$0.30 profit = \$4,500, plus DTC packs ~~\$1,500~~ ****\$5k–\$6k/month**** once accounts are established.

How To Start

1. Order 5,000 units plus a branded sample run from Alibaba.
2. Build a one-page Shopify store and a simple B2B order sheet/line-card.
3. Make a 30-second demo video: drop a lit cigarette in, it goes out — that proof is the whole pitch.
4. Walk into 20 local cafes/bars with patios and leave free samples + a price sheet.
5. Offer venues custom logo printing at a small upcharge to lock them in.

6. List DTC multi-packs on Shopify, Amazon, and TikTok Shop for travelers/campers/smokers.
7. Set up a reorder reminder (GoHighLevel) so venues restock before they run out.

Where To Get Customers

- Direct B2B outreach to cafes, hookah lounges, hotels, golf courses, event venues
- TikTok/Instagram demo clips of the self-extinguish effect
- Amazon and TikTok Shop for consumer multi-packs
- Event and festival organizers (huge bulk orders for outdoor crowds)
- Vending/distributor partners who already service hospitality

Pro Tips

- Lead with the demo, not the description — showing a lit cigarette die in water in 2 seconds sells venue managers faster than any spec sheet.
- The real money is reorders: get venues hooked on the convenience, then automate restock reminders so you become their default supplier.
- Offer free logo printing above a minimum order — branded cups make the venue look premium and make them far less likely to switch suppliers.